

Class 7 History — Our Pasts II

Medieval India, 700–1750 CE | UPSC CSE 2027

Read This First

You've finished Class 6 (*Our Pasts I*, Ancient India, up to ~700 CE). This book picks up exactly where that stopped and runs to **1750** — the eve of British rule.

Where this sits in the pipeline

Class 6	→	Ancient India	(to ~700 CE)	done
Class 7	→	MEDIEVAL India	(700–1750)	← you are here
Class 8	→	Modern India	(1750–1947)	← the big one for marks

 **This book was written from the actual NCERT PDFs**, which are in `../Textbook_PDF/Our_Pasts_II/`. Unlike Class 6 — where NCERT had withdrawn the book and the notes were written from knowledge — every chapter here was read from the source. Where the notes go beyond the textbook, it's marked.

Two chapters have been DELETED from this book

The current edition is the **rationalised 8-chapter** version. The original had **10**. NCERT removed:

Removed chapter	What it covered	Why it matters to you
Rulers and Buildings	Indo-Islamic architecture — trabeate vs arcuate, arches, domes, Qutb Minar, mosques, Mughal gardens, the Taj Mahal	☆☆☆ Heavily asked in Prelims Art & Culture and in Mains GS1 . Losing this is a real gap
Towns, Traders and Craftpersons	Temple towns, Hampi, Masulipatnam, Surat, bidri work, the Vishwakarma artisans, the arrival of European companies	☆☆ Feeds Art & Culture and the run-up to Modern India

I have restored both in `09_Supplement_Rulers_Buildings_Towns_Traders.md`. **Do not skip it** — it is arguably the highest-yield file in this folder.

The Whole Book on One Page

700 CE v	1206 v	1526 v	1707 v	1750 v
REGIONAL KINGDOMS ->	DELHI SULTANATE ->	MUGHAL EMPIRE ->	Aurangzeb dies ->	REGIONAL STATES AGAIN ->
Cholas Rashtrakutas Palas Pratiharas Chahamanas	5 dynasties Slave Khalji Tughluq Savvid Lodi	Babur -> Akbar -> Jahangir -> Shah Jahan -> Aurangzeb	empire unravels	Marathas Sikhs Jats Awadh Bengal Hyderabad
Ch. 2	Ch. 3	Ch. 4		Ch. 8

Running underneath the whole period, not tied to any one dynasty:
Ch.1 how we know Ch.5 tribes & nomads Ch.6 bhakti & sufi Ch.7 regional cultures

The shape to notice: fragmentation → consolidation → fragmentation. **Exactly the rhythm of Class 6** (mahajanapadas → Mauryas → regional states → Guptas → regional states). India's political history pulses.

Chapter Map

#	Chapter	Really about	UPSC Weight
01	Tracing Changes Through a Thousand Years	Sources, terminology, periodisation — the methodology chapter	★ ★ ★
02	Kings and Kingdoms	Samantas, tripartite struggle, the Cholas	★ ★ ★ ★
03	Delhi: 12th to 15th Century	The Delhi Sultanate — five dynasties	★ ★ ★ ★ ★
04	The Mughals	Akbar's administration , mansabdari, zabt	★ ★ ★ ★ ★
05	Tribes, Nomads and Settled Communities	Gonds, Ahoms, Banjaras — the people outside the state	★ ★ ★
06	Devotional Paths to the Divine	Bhakti and Sufi movements	★ ★ ★ ★ ★
07	The Making of Regional Cultures	Kathak, Kerala murals, Bengal, Rajput painting	★ ★ ★ ★
08	Eighteenth-Century Political Formations	Mughal decline, the successor states	★ ★ ★ ★
09	🚩 SUPPLEMENT — the deleted chapters	Indo-Islamic architecture + towns and trade	★ ★ ★ ★ ★

How Medieval India Appears in UPSC

Prelims — moderate volume, high Art & Culture spillover

Medieval History proper is usually **2–4 questions**. But it feeds **Art & Culture**, which is **8–12 questions** — and a large share of that is medieval: Indo-Islamic architecture, Bhakti-Sufi saints, regional painting schools, music and dance.

Highest-yield, ranked:

1. 🚩 **Bhakti and Sufi movements** (Ch.6) — saints, their regions, their languages, their ideas. Asked relentlessly
2. 🚩 **Indo-Islamic architecture** (Ch.9 supplement) — the deleted chapter
3. 🚩 **Delhi Sultanate** (Ch.3) — administrative terms, dynastic order

4. 📖 **Mughal administration** (Ch.4) — mansabdar, jagir, zabt
5. 📖 **Cholas** (Ch.2) — local self-government, bronzes
6. 📖 **Regional cultures** (Ch.7), **18th-century states** (Ch.8), **tribes** (Ch.5)

Mains — GS1, and better than you'd expect

"Indian culture will cover the salient aspects of Art Forms, Literature and Architecture from ancient to modern times."

Medieval is the middle third of that sentence. Real past questions:

- *"Sufis and medieval mystic saints failed to modify either the religious ideas and practices or the outward structure of Hindu/Muslim societies to any appreciable extent. Comment."* (2014)
- *"Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment."* (2020)
- *"Examine the linkages between the nineteenth century's 'Indian Renaissance' and the emergence of national identity."* — needs the medieval baseline

Bhakti-Sufi (Ch.6) is your Mains chapter here, exactly as Ch.10 was in Class 6.

⚠️ The honest weighting

Medieval India is worth **more than Ancient** for Mains (because of Art & Culture) but **less than Modern** overall. Budget **~10 days**. Don't get lost in dynastic detail — UPSC rarely asks "who succeeded whom"; it asks about **institutions, ideas and culture**.

🧵 Five Threads That Run Through the Book

1 From *samanta* to Sultan — how power was legitimised

Ch.2 opens with subordinates (*samantas*) declaring independence and inventing rituals (*hiranya-garbha*) to become Kshatriyas. Ch.3 shows Sultans needing the Caliph's sanction. Ch.4 shows Akbar inventing *sulh-i kul*. **Every ruler in this book has a legitimacy problem, and the solutions are the interesting part.**

2 The state versus the forest

Ch.2's kingdoms clear forests; Ch.5's tribes get displaced; Ch.8's states still can't fully control the frontier. **NCERT keeps returning to who is *outside* the state.** This is your Ch.5 and it connects to GS1 Indian Society.

3 Devotion as dissent

Ch.6 is the heart of the book. **Bhakti and Sufi saints attacked caste, ritual and priestly monopoly — in the vernacular.** Compare directly with Class 6 Ch.6 (Buddha and Mahavira doing the same thing 2,000 years earlier, also in the vernacular). **Same move, different millennium.**

4 Regions don't dissolve, they absorb

Ch.7's argument: pan-regional empires came and went, but **regional cultures kept their distinctiveness while absorbing imperial influence.** Kathak, Manipuri, Kerala's Kathakali, Bengali, Rajput miniatures — all formed in this period.

5 Land revenue is the engine

Chola *vetti* and *kadamai* → Sultanate *iqta* → Mughal *zabt* and *jagir* → 18th-century states keeping the Mughal system while dropping the Mughal. **Follow the revenue system and you understand the politics.**

Suggested Pace — 10 days

Days	Chapters
1	Ch.1 + Ch.2
2–3	Ch.3 (Delhi Sultanate)
3–4	Ch.4 (Mughals)
5	Ch.5
6–7	Ch.6 (Bhakti-Sufi) — slow down, highest yield
8	Ch.7
9	Ch.8
10	Ch.9 supplement (architecture) + revision + quiz

Progress Tracker

- ☐ Ch.1 — Tracing Changes Through a Thousand Years
- ☐ Ch.2 — Kings and Kingdoms
- ☐ Ch.3 — Delhi: 12th to 15th Century
- ☐ Ch.4 — The Mughals
- ☐ Ch.5 — Tribes, Nomads and Settled Communities
- ☐ Ch.6 — Devotional Paths to the Divine
- ☐ Ch.7 — The Making of Regional Cultures
- ☐ Ch.8 — Eighteenth-Century Political Formations
- ☐ Ch.9 —  Supplement (deleted chapters)
- ☐ Full revision
- ☐ Quiz (target 85%+)

How Each Chapter Note Is Built

Same as Class 6:

Block	What it gives you
 Syllabus Classification	Subject, sub-discipline, period, Prelims/Mains relevance, which other papers it feeds, weightage
 Learning Outcomes	Tick-list of what you should be able to <i>do</i>

Then body →  UPSC Focus →  Glossary →  Recap →  Practice questions.

Part of *Mission/History/01_NCERT/* — UPSC CSE 2027. Source PDFs: *../Textbook_PDF/Our_Pasts_II/*
(NCERT, rationalised 8-chapter edition, downloaded 2026-08-05).